Great Swamp Bonsai Society

Next meeting: ***SATURDAY, May 21st***

Guest Artist Will Baddeley

May 2022 Newsletter

May Meeting: Saturday, 4/21, Guest Artist Will Baddeley

Location: **the home of Fred and Doris Aufschlager**, Bernardsville, NJ. (Times to be determined. Stay tuned.)

Our May meeting will feature guest artist **Will Baddeley** from the UK. From his website: "My main interest in Bonsai is working with our native European tree species and also in creating natural looking deadwood on deciduous trees with the use of power tools and scalpels."

We hope to have an afternoon hands-on workshop (bring your own tree, limited number of paying participants), followed by dinner at a local eatery, and an early evening presentation, which will be free to all comers.

Stay tuned for details as they develop.

Bonsai Show! Saturday, May 28th, at Allshapes Bonsai Nursery

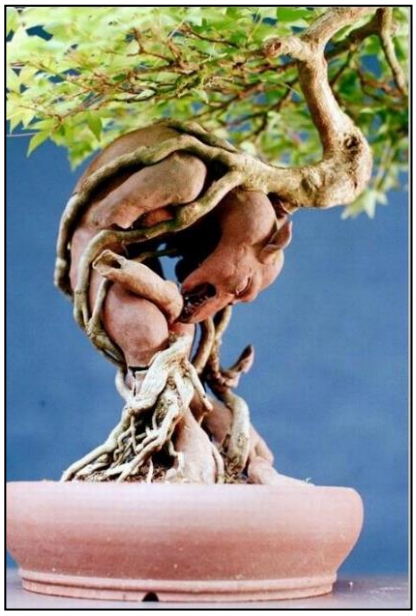
Our friends David and Diane Hall, and Brian Zegar, are hosting a **bonsai show** at their bonsai nursery in **Ringoes, NJ**. **We are invited to bring trees for display**, so please count on joining this special occasion and bring a tree to show! It promises to be a great day of bonsai demos, as well as a wonderful chance to socialize and introduce others to our favorite art form. And if you haven't yet visited **Allshapes**, you'll find it is an excellent resource for bonsai and pre-bonsai material, as well as pots, tools, and all the other accoutrements we rely upon (at prices that won't force you to take out a second mortgage on your house).

We hope to see you there! And bring a friend!

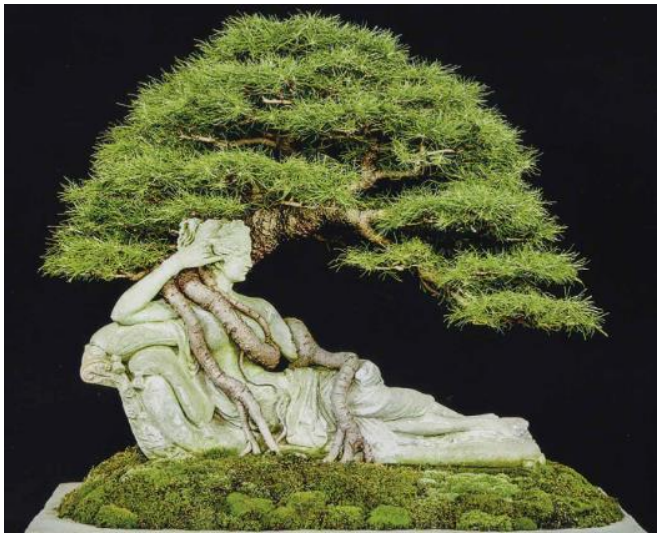
In Memoriam: Nick Lenz

The bonsai community lost a beloved and delightfully eccentric friend in bonsai stylist and potter **Nick Lenz**, who passed away on the morning of Friday April 7th, during a period of treatment for a vascular condition.

Nick was irrepressibly artistic in his pursuit of all things—painting, sculpture, pottery—and provided the world many years of delightful and inspired bonsai, as well as a groundbreaking **book, "Bonsai From the Wild"** which highlighted a variety of native North American species, in what habitats they might be found, and tips for styling each species into rewarding bonsai. The attached photos (all shamelessly lifted without permission by yours truly off the internet) give only a hint of Nick's talent and artistic range. Among Nick's trademarks was his penchant for creating elegant sculptures, upon which he would then train his little trees. He also produced a number of bonsai growing around the "ruins" of gothic cathedrals and such, built of small blocks that he had made and fired, and then cemented, to make the rubble out of which his little trees grew.



He was a joy to learn from, generous with his knowledge, and a hoot to be around. May he rest in peace.



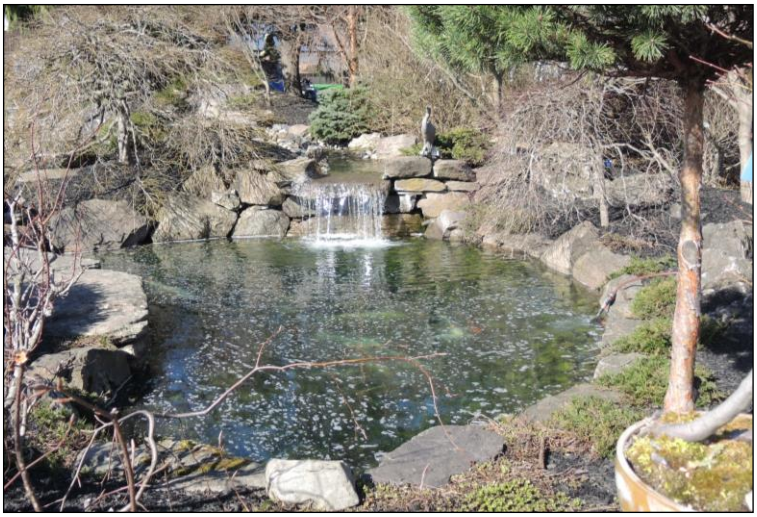
April 30-May 1st: Plant Sale at the Frelinghuysen Arboretum.

GSBS has been invited to **display bonsai** and provide information about the club. Contact John Michalski at huonia@aol.com if interested in helping out.

An outing to the Bonsai Shack in Pomona, NY

On Saturday, April 2nd, John Michalski and Mark Sanders made the drive to a wonderful landscape nursery in Pomona, NY, which is home to **The Bonsai Shack**, owned and operated by **Arnie Friedman**, who is primarily a landscape designer specializing in water features. The main attraction this day was a free demonstration by Italian bonsai artist **Mauro Stemberger**, who performed detailed styling and wiring on a large Scots pine in Arnie's collection. Some photos of the event are shown below.

We encourage you to google the Bonsai Shack for future events. It's a great place and well worth the drive. Thanks to Arnie for hosting such a wonderful event.



March meeting: selection of MABS trees and demonstration on pruning to improve your design

The GSBS met on Saturday, March 26th, at the Morris County Library, to select the trees to represent our club at the MABS Spring Festival. We traditionally make the decision by "penny vote," in which each attendee is given three pennies to place before the trees they would like to go to the show.

This year's trees were an upright Shimpaku Juniper by Rick Myers, a "raft" style Alberta Spruce by Greg Birrer, and windswept Pitch Pine by John Burna. Also representing the club was an upright Ginkgo by Doug Siedenburg, who was not able to attend the March meeting. Congratulations to all, and thanks to everyone who brought in a tree for consideration. You did the club proud!

Also during the meeting, club member John Michalski gave a demonstration on pruning to improve your design, using two large Amur Maples from his collection.

This year's Mid-Atlantic Bonsai Society's Spring Festival.

This year's MABS Spring Festival took place the weekend of April 8-10th, at the Parsippany Hilton on Route 10, in Parsippany NJ. Guest artists were **Kathy Shaner**, **Suthin Sukosolvisit**, and **Bjorn Bjorholm**. The display area was filled with some of the finest trees we have ever shown, the lecture/demos were astounding and well-attended, and the vendors tell me this was one of the best MABS shows they've ever sold at.

If you weren't able to attend this one, plan on doing so next year. It was a truly great event.

Our planned workshop and meeting of April 11th, featuring Bjorn Bjorholm, had to be cancelled due to the necessity of Bjorn having to unexpectedly return home immediately following the MABS weekend. We apologize to those of you who put aside time to attend, and we hope to have Bjorn back for a rematch one of these days. He is a great artist, and it would be a pleasure to host him.

We are collecting DUES again!

The GSBS is reintroducing club dues, at $40.00 for individual, $50.00 for family membership, per year—which was our rate before we suspended dues in 2020. You can pay by cash or check, in person to club treasurer **Rick Myers**, or by mail at his address at the back of this newsletter.

Plant Care Tips for April and May

April is still a decent month for root-pruning, and for digging trees from yard or field. Begin your feeding, pinching, watering, and pruning schedules in earnest. Of course, be mindful of potential cold snaps, and be ready to protect vulnerable plants. The growing season has well and truly begun!

Ask 20 bonsai practitioners about fertilizers, soil mixes, and repotting schedules, and you are liable to receive 20 different answers. Nowadays, with so many genuine bonsai masters making their expertise available via **YouTube**, you can get all kinds of good advice from the people with the most experience, and I encourage you to do so.

As for me, I tend to let individual trees remain in the same pot until I sense that the water is no longer draining well during watering—unless there is an obvious health issue that might require a change of soil mix, or checking on possible root damage. My soil mixes have evolved quite a bit over the past 30 years—frankly, mainly in the direction of pre-packaged professional mixes, or potting mixes fabricated to order by people who have all the right ingredients. In short, I go where the pro's go.

As to fertilizing, for the past several years I've placed my faith in pelleted surface fertilizer (the brand I use is **Osmocote**) that releases small amounts of the good stuff every time you water, or every time it rains. (The products you mix in the watering work fine, too, except that they will leach out when it rains.) I have fortified all my bonsai with this product **this weekend**, as the buds are expanding and leaves are extending. The only exception I make is for refined trees for which I do not wish to encourage excessive growth. For those trees, I hold off on fertilizer until after the first set of leaves has set and hardened off. Everything else gets the full treatment. [JM]

By **May,** most deciduous trees have come into leaf and new candles on pines have sprouted. Watering should now routinely be done once a day. Cuttings of evergreens may still be taken. Air-layering of deciduous and evergreens can be continued. Pinch back long shoots of deciduous trees as sudden frosts can damage the young leaves. [DY]

You can still repot or dig trees in May if you're careful. Begin your feeding, pinching, pruning schedules in earnest. It's growing season, folks! Oddly, in many ways this is easier than the worrying months of winter. [JM]

Save and Bring In Your Discarded Copper Bonsai Wire

Please remember to save and bring in those wire clippings. **It helps if you cut your wire into short (3-6 inch) lengths, as it packs more easily for transport and sale.** About once a year we bring them to a scrap metal dealer and swap them for cash. It's usually about enough to equal one or two paid memberships, so it really does help keep the GSBS afloat.

Repeat: GSBS Facebook Page / GSBS YouTube Channel

A reminder that our club **Facebook Page** is a wonderful venue for anyone in the group to post photos, ask questions, or chime in with ideas and opinions about other people's work and accomplishments. To contribute to the discussion, all you have to do is go to the page and request to join the group—once your request has been accepted, you will be able to post photos, videos, and comments.

We have also established a Great Swamp Bonsai Society **YouTube Channel**, which at the moment features only a few amateur video clips by yours truly (John Michalski), expounding or demonstrating simple maintenance techniques for different species used in bonsai. If you have something you'd like to upload, get in touch with me at huonia@aol.com. Thanks!

Repeat: GSBS Sales Table – "Virtual" Sales Table

We will continue with our recent addition of a "sales table" for any bonsai-related articles that club members wish to offer for sale at our regular meetings. You simply bring your wares and post the prices with them.

In the meantime, feel free to post announcements on our club **Facebook Page** if you have something to sell, or something you are seeking. **(Non-commercial sales only, please. This is not intended as advertising space for full-time professionals.)** This is a good way for members to move along those items they no longer wish to keep, while offering same to other people who might cherish them! So please feel free!

Keep those Topic Suggestions Coming!

A reminder to feel free to send your ideas and topic suggestions to any of the Board Members listed on the last page of this newsletter. GSBS is always looking for new and interesting topics that will appeal to the various educational needs of our diverse membership. The club exists for you, so don't be shy with your recommendations.

We especially welcome volunteers who wish to plan and lead presentations and workshops, so that the club may benefit from the wide array of experience contained within our membership.

Calendar of Events for 2021-2022

A return date to our original meeting room at the Frelinghuysen Arboretum is still uncertain. Please keep venue and topic ideas coming—we are cheerfully open to any and all suggestions!

April 30-May 1st: Plant Sale at the **Frelinghuysen Arboretum**. GSBS has been invited to **display bonsai** and provide information about the club. Contact John Michalski at huonia@aol.com if interested in helping out.

May 21st: Guest artist Will Baddeley, from the UK. Hosted at the home of club member Fred Aufschläger, time to be determined. For information on the artist, look him up under Bonsai Empire.

May 28th: Bonsai Show & Open House at **Allshapes Bonsai Nursery** in Ringoes, NJ. All day! Bring a tree to display! Bring a friend! Bring some money to buy stuff!

June: Picnic hosted at the home of **Peter and Genevieve Michienzi** in **River Edge, NJ.** Date and details to be determined. Stay tuned!

July: Picnic and lesson/demonstration hosted at the home of **Martin Schmalenberg** and **Amy Bridge** in **Stillwater, NJ**. Date and details to be determined. Stay tuned!

GSBS Contact Information:

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Treasurer: Rick Myers spruce80@verizon.net
80 Kenvil Ave
Succasunna N J
07876

Newsletter: John Michalski huonia@aol.com

Club Information

Location: **(If/when we return to "normal.")**

The Frelinghuysen Arboretum
353 East Hanover Ave,
Morristown, NJ 07962

Date:

Usually the second Tuesday of each Month, (check our website for special dates and locations)

Time: 6:30 – 9:30 pm

Remember to check our website (http://www.arboretumfriends.org/gsbonsai/index.htm) for special events, dates, updates and latest information.

Great Swamp Bonsai Society
c/o John Michalski
223 Mount Kemble Ave., Morristown, NJ 07960

Great Swamp Bonsai Society Membership Registration:
Send to:

GSBS c/o Rick Myers _____ **New** _____ **Renewal**
80 Kenvil Avenue
Succasunna, NJ 07876. _____ **Individual ($40)** _____ **Family ($50)**

Name(s): _____ **Email:** _____

Address: _____ **Phone:** (_____)

If Family Membership, please list other members:

_____ _____ _____